



# Identifying Pain Points

Week 1 • Day 4 • Customer-Centric Foundations

Technical Product Manager Academy



## Day 4 Objectives

- Extract pain points from observed behavior, not just stated complaints
- Use **5 Whys** to reach root-cause pain
- Group raw pains into themes via **affinity mapping**
- Score pains on **Severity × Frequency × Addressability**
- Distinguish *pains we must fix* from *pains we must live with*



# Today's Shape

| Clock         | Block                           | Outcome                               |
|---------------|---------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| 09:00 – 09:15 | Opening                         | Persona pains → pain-point candidates |
| 09:15 – 10:30 | Block 1 + Activity 1            | Extraction from evidence              |
| 10:45 – 12:00 | Block 2 + Activity 2            | 5 Whys + affinity mapping             |
| 13:00 – 14:15 | Block 3 + Activity 3            | Severity × Frequency × Addressability |
| 14:30 – 16:00 | Block 4 + Activity 4 + Readouts | Prioritization + must-live-with       |

# Block 1 — Extraction

Where real pain hides



# Where Pains Actually Live

| Source                    | What you see                                                   | Reliability                              |
|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Support tickets           | Failures serious enough to complain about                      | High for severity, low for frequency     |
| Interviews                | Stated frustrations, with emotion                              | Medium; confirmation bias risk           |
| Observation / ride-alongs | Workarounds, sighs, side-channels (paper, shared spreadsheets) | Highest for real pain                    |
| Analytics drop-offs       | Where users quit a flow                                        | High for "what," silent on "why"         |
| Sales/loss reviews        | Why deals didn't close                                         | Medium; filtered through sales narrative |

The best pain points are the ones customers *don't complain about anymore* — because they built a workaround.

## ◆ A Pain Is a Verb

### ✗ Too vague

- "Bad UX"
- "Inefficient workflow"
- "Training problems"
- "Integration issues"

### ✓ Actionable

- "Dispatchers retype parts from paper tickets nightly"
- "Mid-day re-routes require calling 3–4 techs individually"
- "New dispatchers bounce from training after screen 5"
- "Truck inventory is off by end-of-week; no one notices until payroll"

# Activity 1 — Extract From the Packet

Triads • 45 minutes

Your triad receives the FieldPulse **Pain Extraction Packet** — 8 support tickets, 2 ride-along note pages, 4 interview excerpts, 1 analytics screenshot.

- Extract at least 15 candidate pains
- Each pain must be a verb + circumstance + consequence
- Tag source (ticket #, interview initials, observation) for every entry



10 min read • 25 min extract • 10 min review for verb/vagueness

# Block 2 — Root Cause & Themes

5 Whys + affinity mapping





# The 5 Whys, Used Well

Take a pain. Ask "Why does that happen?" Take the answer, ask "Why?" again. Five levels deep (usually fewer) you hit a root cause that is either **systemic** or **out of scope**.

```
L1: Dispatchers close books 45 min after shift end.  
Why? They reconcile paper tickets from the day.  
L2: They reconcile paper tickets.  
Why? Techs submit paper (not mobile) tickets.  
L3: Techs submit paper.  
Why? The mobile app is slow on 3G in the field.  
L4: Mobile app is slow on 3G.  
Why? Ticket submission downloads all open jobs first.  
L5: (Root cause – addressable) – Ticket submission is not  
designed for intermittent connectivity.
```

## Affinity Mapping in 3 Moves

1. **Silent sort:** Each triad member places every pain on the wall (or whiteboard tool).  
No talking.
2. **Cluster:** Group related pains. Name each cluster with a *verb phrase*, not a category.
3. **Promote:** For each cluster, choose 1–2 pains that best represent the whole.

**Silence matters:** The silent-sort step prevents the loudest voice from anchoring the map. Protect it.

## Activity 2 — Dig, Sort, Promote

Triads • 50 minutes

Using your Activity 1 pain list:

- Pick 3 pains that feel "surface-level" — run 5 Whys on each
- Do the silent sort on the full list
- End with 5–8 named clusters, each with 1–2 promoted representative pains



20 min 5 Whys • 20 min silent sort • 10 min cluster + promote

# Block 3 — Severity × Frequency × Addressability

How to say no to real pain



# The Three Axes

| Axis           | Question                       | Scale                                                                 |
|----------------|--------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Severity       | How bad is it when it happens? | Low (annoyance) → Medium (workaround) → High (blocked)                |
| Frequency      | How often does it happen?      | Low (monthly+) → Medium (weekly) → High (daily)                       |
| Addressability | Can we fix it?                 | Low (org/regulatory) → Medium (partial) → High (fully within product) |

**Addressability is the axis PMs forget.** High severity + high frequency + low addressability = we must communicate, not engineer.

# Visualizing the Triangle

Plot each promoted pain in a 3×3 matrix (Severity down × Frequency across), then color-code by addressability.

Sev ↓ / Freq →

Low

High

High

Monitor

Must fix

Low

Accept

Automate / polish

Addressability colors: green = we can amber = partial red = out of scope

A red "Must fix" cell is a **communication problem**, not a product problem.  
Those need stakeholder framing, not JIRA tickets.

## Activity 3 — Score Your Map

Triads • 45 minutes

Place each promoted pain on the 3×3 matrix. Use evidence tiers from Day 1 when judging severity and frequency — don't guess.

- For every **red "Must fix"** pain, draft 2 sentences: "Why we cannot solve this" + "What we will do instead"
- Identify one pain where AI-augmented analysis could raise addressability (e.g., summarizing inbound to reduce support burden)



20 min place · 15 min addressability notes · 10 min AI-leverage

# Block 4 — What We Take Forward

Top 3 pains → Friday's problem statement





## Selecting the Top 3

Each triad picks the **three pains** that will drive Friday's problem statement.

The selection must defend:

1. Why these three over the others? (Matrix position + evidence)
2. Are they *independent*, or aspects of the same root cause?
3. What's the single "if we solved this, everything else is easier" pain?

**Tip:** A great top-3 is often rank-ordered such that #1 unblocks or reduces #2 and #3. If your three feel unrelated, look again for the shared root.

# Activity 4 — Cross-Triad Challenge

Paired triads • 60 minutes • Readouts

Each triad presents Top 3 + matrix to another triad. Partners must:

- Nominate the **weakest** of the three (not based on feel — based on the evidence tag)
- Propose one pain they *didn't* select that might be stronger, with reasoning
- Ask one "so what if we're wrong?" question per pain

After critique: 15 minutes to revise. Each triad readouts its final Top 3 in under 60 seconds.



20 min per direction • 15 min revise • 10 min readouts



## Day 4 Wrap

### What we built

- A scored pain-point matrix per triad
- A Top 3 pain set, rank-ordered and defended
- Language for "pains we must live with"

### What opens tomorrow

- **Data-driven problem framing** — turning Top 3 into a problem statement an engineer can scope
- Friday afternoon: integrated Week 1 readouts

**Bring to Day 5:** Your Top 3 pain sheet with evidence tiers + the one pain you dropped that you're still wrestling with.

# Questions & Reflection

Which pain will you re-interview next week?